



Ultimate Virgin Islands Packing List

2026 Edition • US & British Virgin Islands

In the VI – Practical Travel Guides

The Virgin Islands have expensive shopping, limited stock, strict reef laws, rocky beaches, and intense sun. Packing strategically will save you money, protect the environment, and make your trip smoother.

1. Sun & Reef Protection

- Reef-safe sunscreen (SPF 30–50, mineral-based only – zinc or titanium dioxide).
Required by law in the USVI.
- Wide-brim UPF 50+ sun hat (packable)
- Polarized sunglasses with UV protection
- Rash guard or long-sleeve swim shirt
- Lip balm with SPF

2. Snorkeling & Water Gear

- Quality snorkel mask, dry-top snorkel, and fins (bringing your own is strongly recommended)
- Waterproof dry bag (10–20L) – essential for boat days and beach hopping
- Water shoes or reef-safe sandals (many beaches have rocky entries and sea urchins)

3. Clothing & Footwear

- Multiple swimsuits and quick-dry clothing
- Light long pants or cover-up for evenings and bug protection
- Light rain jacket or compact poncho
- Comfortable walking shoes or sandals with good grip
- **Nice outfit(s)** – if you plan to dine at upscale restaurants

4. Health, Bugs & Personal Care

- Strong insect repellent (no-see-ums are aggressive at dusk)
- Basic first-aid kit, pain reliever, anti-itch cream, and any personal medications
- Hand sanitizer and disinfectant wipes

5. Beach & Boat Day Essentials

- Insulated beach bag or cooler tote
- Quick-dry beach towel
- **Zip-top bags in various sizes** – extremely useful for wet swimsuits, snacks, phones during rain, and organizing gear

6. Electronics & Connectivity

- Portable charger and waterproof phone pouch
- **eSIM or prepaid SIM card** – Verizon users on St. John should be cautious of unexpected international roaming fees from BVI towers.

7. Food & Grocery Strategy

- Many visitors cook at their villa. Consider bringing favorite snacks, protein bars, coffee, and spices.
- **St. John specific tip:** Shop at larger, cheaper stores on St. Thomas before taking the ferry.

8. Documents & Money

- Passport (required for BVI)
- Cash in small bills (very useful for taxis, vendors, and some restaurants)
- Digital + printed copies of reservations, ferry tickets, and travel insurance

9. What NOT to Bring

- Regular chemical sunscreen (illegal in USVI and damages coral)
- Heavy luggage or non-quick-dry clothing
- Expensive jewelry

10. Seasonal Notes

- **Peak Season (Dec–Apr):** Focus on sun protection.
- **Green Season (May–Nov):** Stronger bug repellent and rain gear.

In the VI – Honest, practical guidance for the US & British Virgin Islands